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LETTERS TO MY SON

On Time

16 letters

Father

A father's letters, worth keeping.

A word before you begin

My son,

You will spend your life whether you mean to or not. These letters are on spending it well, before the bill comes due.

Read one a day. Sit with it. Let it change one small thing in how you live.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

You will never have less time than you do today.

Every year the hours cost more and buy less. Spend the cheap ones now, on what matters.

Begin before the price goes up.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

The hours you idle away in youth send the bill in old age.

No man ever wished, at the end, that he had wasted more mornings.

Guard the early hours; they are the seed of the late ones.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

We are not given a short life — we make it short by wasting it.

The problem was never how little time you had. It was how carelessly you spent it.

Live as if the hours were counted, because they are.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Attend to the business in front of you, and to nothing else
in that hour.

The mind that wanders during work works twice and
finishes once.

Give the hour its due and it gives you the day.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

While we wait to live, life passes.

You are postponing the very thing you keep promising to get to.

Stop preparing to begin. Begin.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Fix your natural flaws the way Demosthenes fixed his speech, on purpose, against the wind.

No weakness is permanent for the man willing to drill against it daily.

Choose your flaw and go to war with it.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

It is not that life is short; it is that we waste most of it.

You have enough years. You do not have enough attention.

Spend the hours on your life, not on escapes from it.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Hold every hour in your own hands.

The man who owns his day depends less on tomorrow.

Master today and the future loosens its grip.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

While we delay, life hurries by.

The thing you keep meaning to start is the thing your life
is made of.

Begin the small piece you can do today.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Do one thing at a time, and that thing fully.

The scattered man is busy all day and finished with nothing.

Give the hour one task and it gives you the day.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

No one will give your time back to you.

You guard your money and squander the one thing you cannot earn again.

Spend your hours as the rare coin they are.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

You act as if you will live forever; the time slips out beneath you.

Mortality is not morbid to remember — it is clarifying.

Let the short measure of your days sharpen the long aim of your work.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

An hour of focused work outvalues a day of
half-attention.

Depth, not duration, is what moves a life forward.

Go deep on one thing before you go wide on many.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Take the long view your grandfather could not afford to.

What looks slow across one life looks swift across three.

Plant for the harvest you will not personally eat.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

The busiest men are often the ones least alive.

Motion is not living. A full calendar can hide an empty life.

Be occupied with your purpose, not merely with activity.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Postponement is the largest theft of life.

Every 'someday' quietly removes a today from your account.

Name the day, or admit it will never come.

Yours faithfully,

Father

Keep going

If these served you, there is more.

- A new letter every day — @letters_to_son_eng
- The weekly letter — comment LETTERS to join.
- The full collection and printed keepsakes — coming soon.

Carry these well. One day you may write your own.

Yours faithfully,

Father